





OLDE-WORLDE CHARM
Stills from *The Archies;* (top) Suzanne Caplan Merwanji and (far left) Poornamrita Singh

but also lend a "contemporary feel", making them wearable even today.

What a Beautiful World

After researching hill stations in India both in libraries and online, Suzanne Caplan Merwanji knew she had found her Riverdale on her very first recce of Ooty. Be it Veronica's upscale house [shot at Fern Hill hotel] or the abandoned structures she could refurbish, Merwanji and her team had a field day at the picturesque hill station.

Being married to a Parsi, says Merwanji, helped her understand the aesthetics of Anglo-Indian houses, given the "similarities". Like Singh, she also had to innovate by coming up with wallpaper prints that would fit into the period. Says Merwanji, "There are few readymade wallpapers existing of the time. So we redesigned and ensured they still have the spirit." In addition to houses of the key characters, the *Archies* world also has a newspaper office, a salon, a bookshop and Pop Tate's, the gang's favourite hangout, which meant procuring specific props. Riverdale's town square, seen in the song 'Sunoh' and the trailer, though, was built in five weeks on an empty plot in Mumbai.

Merwanji and Akhtar go way back. They first met on the sets of Mira Nair's *Kama Sutra*, where Akhtar assisted with casting and Merwanji was an assistant set decorator. "We rarely disagree, and for the most part, are on the same plain," says Merwanji, who worked on Akhtar's *Zindagi Na Milegi Dobara* and *Gully Boy*. Once Akhtar emphasised the "storybook" effect, Merwanji says the aim became to achieve a "heightened realism". "At the end, we aren't making a documentary on Anglo-Indians in the 1960s. With all the information, we moved ahead and designed the world that's idyllic and has its own identity," she says. ■

Suhani Singh



He remembers M. Karunanidhi extending support for the sixth edition of the festival as chief minister. He recollects conversations with J. Jayalalithaa. "She asked me what I needed apart from financial support. I suggested that if we could have a five-screen theatre in the place of the old Kalaivanar Arangam, that would be great!" From fondly remembering these interactions, Thangaraj cuts to the nuts and bolts of the festival. Some of the strongest relationships he's built in this journey are with the embassies in New Delhi. To screen a film, there is a screening fee that must be paid to the agencies that hold the rights. "The embassies want to support the agencies and take up the screening fees of some of the films from their countries," says Thangaraj. Australia, Brazil and Hungary are some of the examples he cites. "Australia insisted on showing films based on the indigenous experience, and we will be showing two of them."

With Tamil Nadu's huge film industry, there is never a respite from new releases. Does that make theatre availability a challenge? Thangaraj doesn't think so. "The challenge is a festival centre." He would like to have one central location so that people need not run from one location to another to catch films. "This time, we have three screens within the PVR (formerly Sathyam) complex in addition to our regular Anna theatre, and that's a plus. We were also able to negotiate five shows per day."

The main challenge is financial. "If you look at big festivals like IFFI or IFFK, they are state-funded. If we get sufficient funds from the state, we do not need to bother external entities," says Thangaraj. When we spoke, he was preparing the schedule and insisted on the quality of this year's lineup. Cannes biggies like Justine Triet's *Anatomy of a Fall* and Aki Kaurismäki's *Fallen Leaves* are part of it. The world cinema category includes 2023's best like *The Teacher's Lounge, Do Not Expect Too Much From the End of the World, Inshallah a Boy, How to Have Sex, Perfect Days* and *Afire*. ■

Aditya Shrikrishna